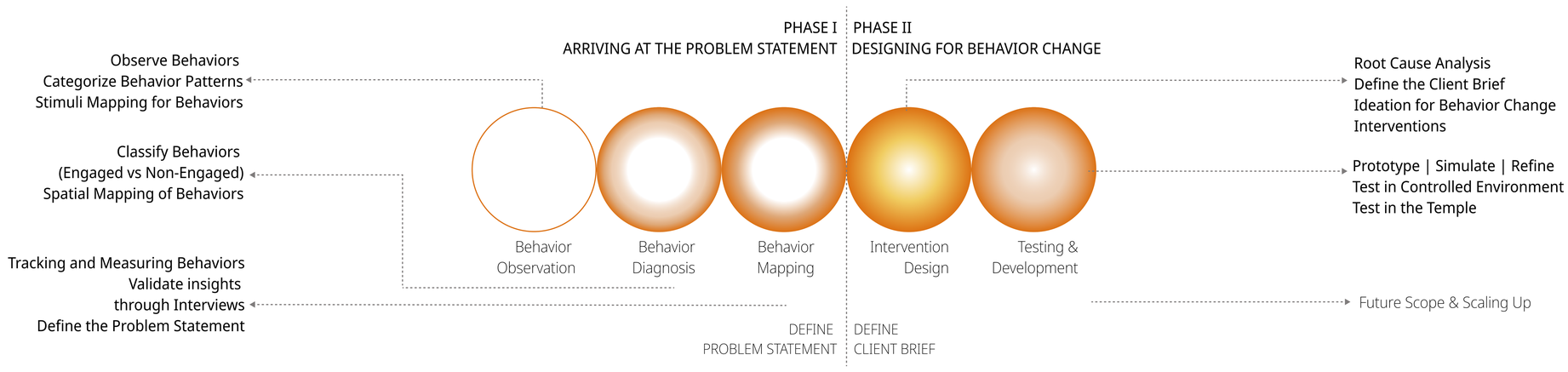
Human Behaviour & Strategies | Temples

राष्ट्रीय डिज़ाइन संस्थान
NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF DESIGN



Timeline : 5 weeks

Anchor Faculty : Guru Prasad S
Visiting Faculty : Leslee Lazar
Team: Dharvi Prajapati | Vysali Chadalavada

Scope of Work : "To analyse human behaviour, identify Deviancies and Underlying Patterns, and Design Interventions that Encourage Positive Behavioural Change by Enhancing, Eliminating, Re-Orienting, or Establishing Behaviours.

Phase I : Arriving at the Problem Statement

Primary Research:

We visited 12 Hindu religious temples around Gandhinagar & Ahmedabad to understand how various stakeholders behave inside the mandir premises, their roles and how do they interact with the space through slow ethnography. After an initial observation spanning a week, we recorded 186 behaviours exhibited inside the space using observation logs, photo documentation and spatial behaviour mapping.

Research Tools:



Categorisation of observed behaviours

We categorize behaviors to transform a chaotic stream of human actions into structured data patterns.

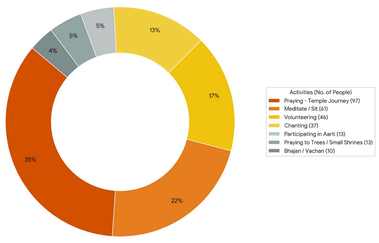
Devotional Engagement	Social & Cultural Behavior	Spatial Behavior	Visitor Groups	Sensory Behaviour	Transactional Behaviour
Spiritual Immersion	Social interaction	Space Utilization	Individual devotees	Hygiene	Transactional behavior
Ritual Routines	Social norms	Movement patterns	Family Groups	Distractions	Educational modes
	Heirarchy	Gathering Zones	Friend Groups	Sensory triggers	
	Cultural Influence	Underutilized Spaces	Elderly		
	PDA / Boundary Behaviors		Children		
Visitors follow a fixed ritual sequence such as ringing the bell, offering flowers, circumambulating the shrine, and receiving prasad before leaving.	There are (old) people take care of the temple and the rituals of the temples. These people take it upon themselves to enforce the rules and regulations of the temples onto the visitors.	Visitors gather in shaded courtyards or steps to rest and converse, while other peripheral areas remain largely unused.	Families often look for open areas where children can move around, sometimes turning quiet spaces into informal resting or play areas.	The ringing of bells near the garbhagriha acts as a strong auditory cue, prompting devotees in surrounding areas to move closer and gather near the sanctum.	Some visitors enter the temple premises primarily to access essential amenities such as clean drinking water and affordable hygienic food.
People sit in meditation with their hands on their knees, counting on their fingers, and murmuring the chants	Groups of visitors pause in temple corridors or courtyards to talk, greet acquaintances, or discuss rituals and temple traditions.	Couples or small groups sit in less monitored areas such as gardens or back corridors, using them for private interaction rather than temple engagement.	Older visitors stay longer and engaging calmly with the environment, other visitors, and the temple staff.	Vocal cues like chants initiated by devotees often energizes the crowd and strengthens collective devotional participation.	Devotees often buy flowers, coconuts, incense, or prasad from vendors before entering the temple, making the act of purchasing offerings an integral part of their temple visit.

Quantifying engaged & Non-engaged behaviours (As per the observations)



ENGAGING BEHAVIOUR

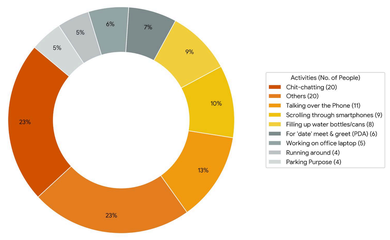
Frequency of Engaging Activities by Number of Participants (n=100)





NON-ENGAGING BEHAVIOUR

Frequency of Non-Engaging Activities by Number of Participants (n=70)



Analysing overlapping behaviours from observations & validating it with the Mandir authorities (Defining problem area)

ELIMINATE

- **Elevated voice levels and loud conversations within the inner and outer mandir premises**
- **Couples showing PDA (public display of affection) holding hands, hugging or engaging in intimate behaviour**
- **Mobile phone use inside temple premises that disrupts the sanctity (taking calls, letting phone ring, speaking loudly, scrolling, and watching videos)**

ENHANCE

- **Voluntary visitor participation in temple upkeep (cleaning premises, helping with crowd control, assisting other visitors in way-finding, prasad distribution, arranging mats or seating areas, etc.)**
- **Visitors sponsoring Annadaan/prasad, bringing food to distribute, offering food to other visitors or the needy in the temple premises**
- **Encouraging devotees to engage in devotional "bhajan and kirtan" to deepen spiritual immersion**

1 Elevated voice levels and loud conversations within the inner and outer mandir premises

2 Couples engaging in PDA (public display of affection) holding hands, hugging or engaging in intimate behaviour

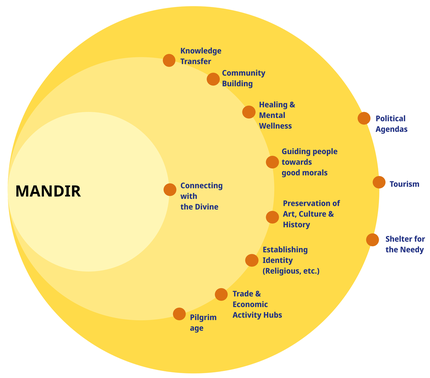
3 Voluntary visitor participation in temple upkeep (cleaning premises, helping with crowd control, assisting other visitors in way-finding, prasad distribution, arranging mats or seating areas, etc.)

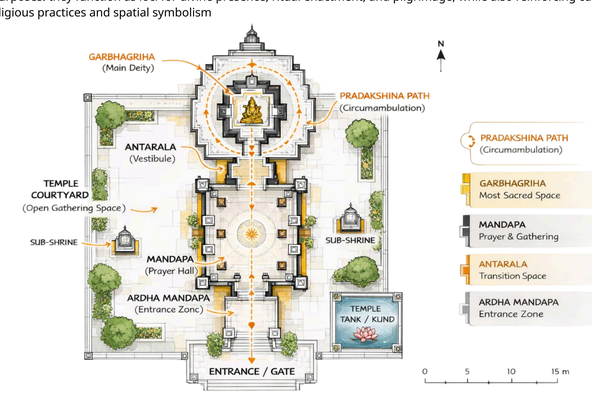




Secondary Research

The construction of Hindu temples serves both spiritual and socio-cultural purposes: they function as loci for divine presence, ritual enactment, and pilgrimage, while also reinforcing cultural identity, collective memory, and community engagement through shared religious practices and spatial symbolism





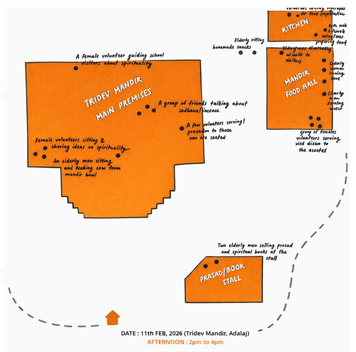
Temples were embedded in communities as socio-spiritual nodes that structure collective behavior, facilitate ritual practices, and strengthen cultural continuity through shared spaces, experiences, and symbolic meaning. Hindu temple architecture follows a hierarchical spatial planning system where devotees gradually transition from public spaces such as courtyards to the most sacred space, the Garbhagriha. Each architectural zone supports different forms of engagement, including social interaction, ritual movement, prayer, and meditation, making the temple both a spiritual and community space.

Spatial mapping of engaging & Non-engaging behaviour

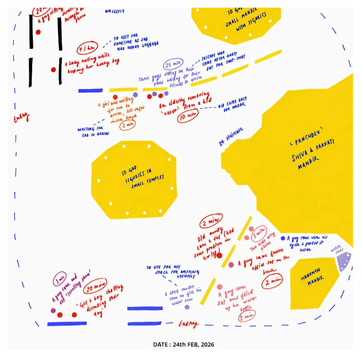
Spatial mapping was used to document engaging and non-engaging behaviours within the mandir premises by recording the type of activity, its location, and the duration of stay. This helped identify how different spatial conditions influence user behaviour, revealing where people pause, interact, or simply pass through, and highlighting patterns of engagement within the space.

These insights help uncover spatial opportunities where design interventions can be strategically introduced to enhance user experience and activate underutilized areas while respecting the cultural context of the mandir.

ENGAGING BEHAVIOUR



NON-ENGAGING BEHAVIOUR

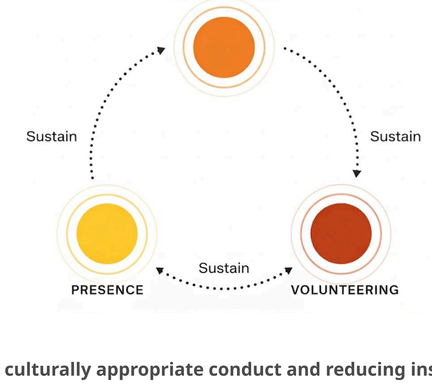




Why "PDA" inside a mandir premises (Root cause analysis mapping)

Low lit space	Less observed areas	Shadows becomes more prominent	L-shaped corridors or sharp turns where you cannot see what is ahead.	Improperly placed lights that "blind" cameras or people	Creates a **private & intimate space**
	Peripheral vision becomes weaker	Boundaries, pathways, and spatial elements become unclear	People walk more carefully	Insufficient or broken lighting	Makes it impossible to **identify faces or actions**
Non-engaging spots					
Secluded Spaces	Unmaintained landscaping, high hedges, or dense trees	Often found behind buildings	Presence of uncollected litter		False sense of **social norms become relaxed**
Low foot traffic areas	The space is not on a main walking route	Spaces without tasks, rituals, or services often remain unused	If only a few people are present, visitors may feel too visible or awkward	The area may not have a clear reason to visit	Allow **longer engagement**
Far away spots	Visual cues or signage often decrease	Spots located at the boundaries	Fewer people pass through the space regularly	Multiple ways to enter or exit without passing through the premises	Distance provides a **"buffer zone"**
Low surveillance spaces	Absence of CCTV cameras, lighting, or signage indicating surveillance.	Even if cameras exist, they may be poorly placed or not obvious.	Areas where camera coverage is non-existent, obstructed, or poorly maintained.	Visually disconnected from busy zones	Sense of **temporary ownership of the space**
	Security staff, guards, or responsible figures are rarely present				

The Temple Community Building (Framework)



Problem Statement : How might we introduce a new behaviour to alter visitor journey and spatial touchpoint within the temple precinct to foster a sense of 'sacred mindfulness,' effectively nudging visitors toward culturally appropriate conduct and reducing instances of public displays of affection (PDA) without resorting to aggressive policing

College Simulation Testing

At NID college we screened a movie at "Top of the world" a know PDA spot, to see what if other students were keen on coming and engaging with the space. We later talked to students to understand why are these spots not engaging ? Also what lead the other students to engage with these spots while we screened the movie.





Factors affecting engagement	The spot was far-away & secluded	No study-friendly seating	Students avoid witnessing PDA	It feels awkward to enter or leave the space	Fear of administrative trouble	
	Being assumed to be meeting someone romantically	Isn't a functional space, low WIFI network				
Factors leading to engagement	Now have a neutral excuse to use the space	There are more people for the same purpose	Escaping the regular classroom or hostel setup	It becomes a new space to explore, you can stargaze while you watch movie	Peer pressure from friends	
How to enhance experience	Good lighting instead of dim corners	Snack kiosks, Water stations, Charging points, Study-friendly tables	More frequent movie screenings	Add another social hook beyond the movie	creates a better "sound stage" effect	

Phase II : Designing for Behaviour Change

Client Brief : How Might We Activate the Non-Engaged Spaces in the Temple to Encourage Meaningful Visitor Engagement and Enhance the Overall Temple Experience?

Possible Design Interventions

Enhancing non-engaging mandir spaces requires designing for behaviour, not just form. By using sensory cues and interactive rituals, spaces can encourage devotees to pause, reflect, and participate rather than pass through. These interventions foster emotional connection, social belonging, and a sense of shared responsibility. Ultimately, they shift visitors from passive presence to active engagement and sustained involvement.



1 **Giving the Non-Engaged Area an Identity**
"1000 years old tree"

Framing the existing tree as a heritage landmark with subtle storytelling and seating can transform it into a contemplative gathering point, activating the space while encouraging meaningful engagement with the temple environment.

Problems Addressed

- Activates an otherwise overlooked natural element by giving it cultural and historical significance.
- Distributes visitor presence away from crowded zones while maintaining a spiritual atmosphere.



2 **Light and Water Fountains**

Soft light and water features can make underutilized areas visually and sensorially engaging, encouraging visitors to pause and gather while maintaining a calm, spiritual atmosphere.

- Encourages visitors to pause and spend time in the space rather than passing through quickly.
- Enhances the aesthetic and experiential quality of the temple environment.



3 **Projection-mapped Deity Visuals**
with immersive Aarti Verses Playing along

Projection mapping with subtle deity visuals and aarti verses can create immersive devotional moments, drawing visitors toward these spaces and fostering collective spiritual engagement.

- Introduces devotional engagement in spaces beyond the main sanctum.
- Strengthens the sacred atmosphere while guiding visitor attention toward meaningful experiences.



4 **Pressure-sensitive steps with integrated lighting**
that light up automatically when someone steps on them

Interactive steps that light up when stepped on can guide visitor movement through the space, encouraging exploration while enhancing safety and visual engagement.

- Encourages exploration of pathways that may otherwise be ignored.
- Creates an interactive and memorable spatial experience for visitors. Improves visibility and navigation subtly guiding movement.



5 **Installation of Subtle Reflective Surfaces**
(embedded in the architecture) as a sitting space

Reflective architectural elements can create moments of visual intrigue and awareness, prompting visitors to pause, observe their surroundings, and engage more thoughtfully with the space.

- Introduces visual intrigue that draws attention to architectural elements.
- Encourages visitors to pause and become more aware of the surrounding space.



6 **Sacred Ownership & Community Stewardship**

Enable visitors to symbolically "own" trees, water features, or lamps through named donation plates and simple care rituals. This fosters a sense of belonging and shared responsibility, encouraging respectful use and protection of the space.

- Visitors feel part of a larger community contributing to the temple building
- Encourages devotees to mindfully engage with the space and have a sense of ownership